

The complete technical checklist

The 5 files your website must have to be read by ChatGPT, Perplexity and Gemini

A practical guide for small businesses and sole traders without a marketing team — Part 2 of 3
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Why this checklist exists

In Part 1 you understood why AI search engines probably cannot find your business. Your website does not have the technical structure that ChatGPT, Perplexity and Gemini expect to find.

This guide is the next step: a concrete checklist of the 5 files every website must have to be read correctly by AI search engines. For each one you will find what it is, what it must contain, and how to check whether your website already has it.

No technical knowledge required. This guide is written for small business owners, not for people who know how to code.

How to use this checklist

For each file you will find three pieces of information:

What it is: a simple explanation of what that file does.

What it must contain: the minimum elements the file needs to be useful to AI search engines.

How to check it: how to verify whether your website already has it, without technical knowledge.

At the end of the checklist you will find a summary table to use as a quick reference.

The 5 files in the checklist

File 1: schema.org

What it is: Schema.org is a structured language that describes your business in a way AI search engines can understand. It goes directly into the HTML of your website as a JSON-LD code block. Without it your website is anonymous text: AI search engines do not know who you are, what you do, where you are.

What it must contain:

- @type: the type of business (LocalBusiness, Restaurant, LodgingBusiness, etc.)
- name: the name of your business
- address: full address including street, city, postcode, country
- telephone: phone number
- url: website address
- description: a clear and complete description of your business
- areaServed: the geographic areas you serve
- openingHours: opening hours (if applicable)

How to check it: Go to search.google.com/test/rich-results, enter your website URL and check whether a schema.org block appears. If the page is empty or shows errors, the file is missing or incomplete.

File 2: robots.txt

What it is: The robots.txt file tells web crawlers which parts of your site they can read and which they cannot. Most websites have a robots.txt configured for traditional search engines, but do not include the modern AI crawlers that arrived later.

What it must contain:

- User-agent: GPTBot (ChatGPT/OpenAI crawler)
- User-agent: PerplexityBot (Perplexity crawler)
- User-agent: Google-Extended (Google/Gemini AI crawler)
- User-agent: ClaudeBot (Anthropic/Claude crawler)
- Allow: / for each of the crawlers above
- The link to sitemap.xml at the end of the file

How to check it: Type in your browser: yoursite.com/robots.txt. If you see a text page with crawler instructions, the file exists. Check whether it contains the names GPTBot and PerplexityBot. If you do not see them, the file is incomplete for AI search engines.

File 3: sitemap.xml

What it is: The sitemap.xml is the map of your website: it lists all existing pages and tells crawlers where to find them. Without a sitemap, AI crawlers may not find some important pages, especially blog posts.

What it must contain:

- The URL of every page on your site (homepage, about, services, contact)
- The URL of every blog post (essential for AI visibility)
- The date of the last modification of each page
- It must always be updated when you add new pages or posts

How to check it: Type in your browser: yoursite.com/sitemap.xml. If you see an XML page with a list of URLs, the sitemap exists. If you see a 404 error, the sitemap is missing.

File 4: llms.txt

What it is: The llms.txt file is a text file designed specifically for language models (LLMs) like ChatGPT, Perplexity and Gemini. It gives instructions on how to read your site and what they can use in their responses. It is a new standard but one that is being adopted rapidly.

What it must contain:

- The name and description of your business
- The main pages of the site with their URLs
- An AI Permissions section that declares what AI models can do with the content
- Contact details for specific requests

How to check it: Type in your browser: yoursite.com/llms.txt. If you see a text file with information about the site, the file exists. If you see a 404 error, the file is missing.

File 5: ai.txt

What it is: The ai.txt file complements robots.txt with specific permissions for AI crawlers. While robots.txt manages general access, ai.txt explicitly declares what AI systems can do with the content of your website.

What it must contain:

- The access declaration for the main AI crawlers
- Explicit permissions for the use of content in AI responses
- Contact information for the site manager
- The date the file was last updated

How to check it: Type in your browser: yoursite.com/ai.txt. If you see a text file, the file exists. If you see a 404 error, the file is missing.

Summary: your quick checklist

Use this table to quickly check the status of your website. For each file note whether it is present, missing or to be checked.

schema.org	Check at search.google.com/test/rich-results
robots.txt	Go to yoursite.com/robots.txt — check for GPTBot and PerplexityBot
sitemap.xml	Go to yoursite.com/sitemap.xml — must list all pages
llms.txt	Go to yoursite.com/llms.txt — must exist and have AI Permissions
ai.txt	Go to yoursite.com/ai.txt — must exist with explicit AI permissions

A real example: Casa Cavour after Part 1

After implementing the 5 elements described in Part 1, Casa Cavour (B&B in Bertinoro, Romagna) achieved these measurable results:

4.3/10	3.2/10	4-8
Perplexity score after optimisation	Gemini score after optimisation	Weeks to first results

Your next steps

- 1

Check the 5 files on your website
Use the checklist above. Note what is missing.
- 2

Follow @aimbyvns on Instagram
To receive Part 3: the complete real case with updated Casa Cavour data.
- 3

Book your free consultation
30 minutes to analyse your website together and understand what to add.

Book your free consultation

30 minutes to analyse your website's AI visibility. No commitment. Just concrete answers.

Book your free consultation

This guide is part of a series of 3 free resources by AI'm by VNS. Part 3 (real case study with data) is available at aim-vns.com/resources as soon as it is published. Follow @aimbyvns on Instagram to stay updated.